were significant personnel overlaps between the two, as well as with MDI. Some of the Saudis based in Kunar, where the nascent Lashkar organization also trained, later joined al-Qaeda.[43] For example, a Saudi national named Abdul Rahman al-Surayhi [a.k.a. Abdul Rahman al-Sherahi] was Lakhvi's brother-in-law and reportedly played a role in organizing MDI's early training camps in Afghanistan, where Lakhvi is said to have been one of the main trainers.[44] He was also an associate of Osama bin Laden, on whose behalf he traveled back to Saudi Arabia to recruit others for the Afghan jihad.[45] The most obvious example was Azzam, who not only established and oversaw the Maktab al-Khidmat, but was also one of the original seventeen founding members of MDI.

After the Soviet withdrawal from Afghanistan, the call to jihad continued to resonate among the broader jihadi movement. Its leaders asserted that because Muslims remained oppressed by unbelievers in other locations around the world, defensive jihad must continue globally as part of an obligatory nomadic jihad.[46] The cessation of jihad in Afghanistan thus marked not an end, but rather the beginning of a transnational jihad waged on a number of fronts. Lashkar militants were part of this jihadi road show, and as the next chapter will detail its cadres fought in Tajikistan and Bosnia-Herzegovina as well as in Indian-administered Kashmir during the early 1990s. This reinforced its pan-Islamist tendencies and also enabled it to foster relationships with other jihadi outfits from beyond South Asia that were active on these fronts. However, Lashkar was arguably influenced more by local and regional dynamics.

The Jihadi Milieu

Approximately 95 per cent of the Pakistani population is Muslim, about 75–80 per cent of which are Sunni and 15–20 per cent Shia.[47] The Sunni Hanafi school of jurisprudence, to which both Barelvis and Deobandis subscribe, has predominated in South Asia since at least the turn of the thirteenth century CE.[48] Doctrinally, the Ahl-e-Hadith abjure association with any school of jurisprudence. Almost 80 per cent of Sunni Muslims in Pakistan, or close to 60 per cent of the overall population, subscribe to the Barelvi tradition of Islam, which is syncretic, blending Islam with ancient South Asian religious practices. This tradition has historically served as a